

POU11011 — Short assignment: the blog post

30% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

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The short version

Weight	30% of the module mark
Length	800 words. References, links and image captions do not count
Format	A blog post — rigorous, but not an academic essay
Prompts released	[TBD] — roughly three weeks before the deadline
Due	[TBD], expected around the review week (w/c 26 October), 23:00
Submission	Word or PDF via Blackboard (Turnitin), Assignment Submission Form as page 1
Sources	At least two academic readings or materials from the module

What you are actually being asked to do

Take one concept from the module and use it to make sense of one real political situation.

That is the whole task. It is the core move of the discipline, and it is what the final essay asks you to do at greater length and with more at stake. This is the rehearsal.

Note what it is *not*. It is not a summary of a concept. It is not a news report with a bit of theory sprinkled over the top. The concept has to do work — it has to make you see something in the case that you would not have seen without it, and you have to show me the seeing.

Depth beats breadth every time. One concept, one case, 800 words. A post that gestures at power *and* the state *and* legitimacy will lose to one that takes the second face of power seriously for three paragraphs.

What a blog post is

This is a genre most of you have never written for marks, so here is the spec.

A blog post **integrates your own perspective with evidence and analysis**. It is less formal than an academic essay, and it lets you be creative with structure. In practice that means:

- **A hook.** Open on the case, the puzzle, or a fact that should bother the reader. Not “In this blog post, I will argue...”. Never that.
- **Short paragraphs**, headings, and bold text where they earn their place.
- **Links and images** are welcome, and **do not count toward the word limit**. A link to the article you are analysing is worth more than a sentence describing it. Caption any image; do not decorate.
- **First person is fine.** “I think the interesting thing here is...” is allowed, and often better than the passive constructions students reach for when they are nervous.
- **Referencing is still required.** Informal register, formal citation. At least two module readings, cited properly, with a short reference list at the end. The list does not count toward the word limit.

Two things it is not: a personal opinion piece with citations bolted on, and an academic essay with subheadings inserted. If you can delete every heading and lose nothing, you have written the second one.

Good models to read before you start: the [LSE blogs](#), [The Conversation](#), [Good Authority](#) (the successor to the Monkey Cage). Notice how fast they get to the point, and how often the second sentence is already the argument.

A structure that works

Not a template you must follow — but if you are stuck, this shape gets a good mark with 800 words.

1. **The hook (100 words).** The case, concretely. What happened, and what about it is odd.
2. **The claim (50 words).** One sentence saying what you are going to argue. Put it early. Blog readers do not wait.
3. **The concept (150 words).** Name it, define it properly, cite where it comes from. This is the only stretch where you are allowed to sound like a textbook, and it should be the shortest part you are tempted to write.
4. **The work (400 words).** Apply it. Two or three moves, each with a specific detail from the case. This is where the mark is won.
5. **The limit (100 words).** What your concept does *not* explain about this case, or what the strongest objection would be. First-years skip this; it is the single cheapest way to move from a II.1 to a I.

The prompts

The prompt options are released roughly three weeks before the deadline, and they will be tied to whatever is actually happening in the world in October 2026. That is deliberate: I would rather you analysed something live than something safely settled.

The versions below are the standing concept-anchored forms, so you can start thinking now. The released versions will name specific cases.

[DECISION for Noah — the final prompt list is yours. Below are drafts anchored to the portable concepts from lectures 1–10. Pin each to a live case ~3 weeks before the deadline; last year’s prompts named the case in the question itself, which worked.]

Prompt A — Power

Pick a recent political decision or non-decision. Using the **three faces of power**, work out where the power actually lay. Which face best explains what happened — and how would somebody disagree with you?

The strongest versions of this take on the second or third face, where the evidence is hard. The weakest ones describe a vote.

Prompt B — The state

Choose a state in the news. Using **state capacity** — and distinguishing coercive, extractive and administrative capacity — explain one thing that state is failing, or managing, to do. What does the case show about why capacity is not one number?

Prompt C — Ideology

Take a live political controversy. Show what a **liberal**, a **conservative** and a **socialist** answer to it would actually be — not the caricatures, the serious versions — and say which one the policy on the table most resembles.

Prompt D — Regimes and measurement

Take a country that is genuinely hard to classify as democratic or authoritarian. Using one concept from the regimes lectures (**polyarchy**, **competitive authoritarianism**, or a specific index), argue for where it sits — and say what is at stake in the label.

How it is marked

Against the module rubric: **argument · use of concepts · evidence · structure and writing · referencing**, mapped to the Trinity marking bands. The full one-page rubric is in [the marking rubric](#) — read it before you write, not after you get the mark back.

For this piece specifically, the two criteria that separate the top of the pile from the middle are **use of concepts** (is the concept doing work, or being described?) and **evidence** (are there real specifics from a real case?).

Common failure modes

These are the ones that actually turn up, in rough order of frequency.

- **Describing the concept instead of using it.** Two hundred words defining the three faces of power, then three hundred summarising a news story, and no point where they touch. This caps you in the II.2 range no matter how well written it is.

- **Too many concepts.** See above about depth.
- **No case, or a case the size of a continent.** “Democracy in Europe” is not a case. A single decision, election, protest, court ruling or piece of legislation is.
- **The essay in disguise.** Formal register, no hook, headings bolted onto five paragraphs of continuous prose. You lose marks in *structure and writing* because the brief was a blog post.
- **Decoration mistaken for format.** Bold on every third phrase, a stock photo of a ballot box, four headings for 800 words. Formatting has to earn its place.
- **Sources that are not sources.** Two module readings, minimum, cited properly. A link to a newspaper is evidence about the case, not an academic source. And do not ask a chatbot for references — it invents them, and a fabricated citation is a fabricated citation regardless of where it came from.
- **Over the word limit.** 800 words is a limit, not a target. Going over incurs a penalty of three per cent. State your word count at the top.

Submission

- Word or PDF, via the assignment folder on Blackboard, which submits to Turnitin.
- **The School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form must be page 1**, with the plagiarism declaration and the GenAI disclosure completed. A submission without one is not accepted and accrues late penalties until it is resubmitted with one. The form does not count toward your word limit.
- State your word count at the top of the post.
- Back it up, and submit early enough to survive a technical problem. Keep the receipt.

Late work, extensions and the GenAI permissions for this assessment are in the [module outline](#) — they are the same for every component and are not repeated here.